

Addendum to the Alumni Association Newsletter August 2026

Alums:

A couple of months ago, I had the notion of mentioning in the August Alumni Association newsletter the two former SRI staff members who perished in the 2001 9/11 attack. Alas, I then forgot to include it. The following is an addendum to the August issue.

If you take the path from the south end of the Engineering Building to the cafeteria, you'll see a bench alongside the path with a small plaque on it. The bench and plaque were placed there in a ceremony held on 15 November 2001 to commemorate two former SRI employees: Melissa Harrington Hughes and Max Hammond. Both of these remarkable people joined SRI in 1996, and both spent 4-5 years here, leaving SRI not long before they lost their lives in the 9/11 attack.

Melissa Harrington Hughes worked in the International Policy Group and became the program manager of work related to the economics of Chinese technology. She left SRI to become Director of Business Development at a local firm called Slam Dunk Networks. In that role she



was attending a conference on the 101st floor of the North Tower of the World Trade Center when the first plane struck. Melissa had time to call her father and leave a voicemail message for her husband, Sean, before the tower collapsed. Her phone message to Sean was played on news stations around the world in the weeks following 9/11.



Max Hammond joined SRI as a PhD physicist in the Applied Electromagnetics Lab. A seemingly odd interest in that lab was wave mechanics, but of the fluid, not electromagnetic, kind. To help understand the very complex ocean-shore wave interface, Max built a wave machine (named the Max Hammond Wave Facility after his death) to help model that interaction. If you are curious enough to dig deeper, go to <https://scixplorer.org/abs/2004AGUFMOS11A0482P/abstract>.

Max's hobby was tinkering with Ford Mustangs, of which he had a "herd". He left SRI early in 2001, moving east to join the MITRE Corporation. He was on the ill-fated United Flight 175, the second plane that crashed into the South Tower.

That dreadful day sent a broad message. As mentioned, and in a gracious outreach, it prompted SRI to honor these two at a special occasion held outdoors where the memorial bench now sits. A description of that event with pictures and more about Melissa and Max can be found on Page 6 of the April 2002 issue of this newsletter. <https://srialumni.org/newsletters/2002/AlumNews-Apr-2002.pdf>. As to the nation's wound itself, it unfortunately still seems to be playing out a quarter of a century later.

- Don Nielson